

Average Daily Exercise Time of Adults in the United States: A Comprehensive Analysis

Executive Summary:

This report examines the average time spent exercising daily by adults in the United States, drawing upon data from recent studies and guidelines from leading health organizations. While the recommended physical activity level for adults is at least 150 minutes of moderate-intensity aerobic activity per week, translating to approximately 30 minutes per day for five days, research indicates a disparity between these guidelines and actual exercise habits. Data from national surveys reveal that a significant portion of the adult population does not meet these recommendations, and the average time spent engaging in sports, exercise, and recreation varies depending on the source and methodology used. Furthermore, exercise habits differ across demographic groups, with age, gender, race/ethnicity, and socioeconomic status all playing a role. Understanding these variations and the gap between recommendations and reality is crucial for informing public health strategies aimed at promoting more active lifestyles and improving overall health outcomes.

Recommended Physical Activity Guidelines for US Adults:

Leading health authorities in the United States, including the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention (CDC) and the National Institutes of Health (NIH), provide comprehensive guidelines for physical activity to promote health and well-being.¹ For adults aged 18 to 64, the cornerstone recommendation is to engage in at least 150 minutes of moderate-intensity aerobic activity per week. This can also be achieved through 75 minutes of vigorous-intensity aerobic activity per week, or an equivalent combination of both.¹ These guidelines often illustrate this recommendation by suggesting 30 minutes of moderate activity on at least five days of the week.¹ In addition to aerobic activity, adults are advised to participate in muscle-strengthening activities at least two days each week, working all major muscle groups.¹

The guidelines acknowledge that physical activity recommendations vary for specific populations. Older adults, aged 65 years and older, should aim to follow the adult guidelines if possible, while also incorporating activities to improve balance, especially if they are at risk of falls.⁴ Pregnant and postpartum women, who are healthy and not already active, are also encouraged to achieve at least 150 minutes of moderate-intensity aerobic activity per week.⁴ For children and adolescents aged 6 to 17, the recommendation is even higher, with a need for 60 minutes or more of moderate- to vigorous-intensity physical activity daily.⁴

It is important to understand the difference between moderate and vigorous intensity activities. Moderate-intensity activities are those that noticeably increase your heart rate and breathing, such as brisk walking, water aerobics, or cycling on level ground.³

Vigorous-intensity activities significantly increase your heart rate and breathing, making it

harder to talk, such as jogging, swimming laps, or cycling fast or uphill.³ A general rule of thumb is that one minute of vigorous-intensity activity is equivalent to about two minutes of moderate-intensity activity in terms of health benefits.³ The current understanding also emphasizes that even short bouts of physical activity can be beneficial and contribute towards meeting the overall weekly goals.⁵ These recommendations are based on extensive research and are regularly updated, as reflected in the second edition of the Physical Activity Guidelines for Americans.¹⁴

Average Daily Exercise Time Based on Research:

While the guidelines provide a clear target for physical activity, data on the actual exercise habits of the US adult population reveals a more nuanced picture. The CDC's National Health Interview Survey (NHIS) provides valuable insights into the percentage of adults meeting these guidelines.¹⁶ According to 2020 data, approximately 46.9% of adults aged 18 and over met the Physical Activity Guidelines for aerobic physical activity. However, only 24.2% met the guidelines for both aerobic and muscle-strengthening activity.¹⁶ This indicates that a significant majority of US adults are not achieving the recommended levels of physical activity. The American Time Use Study (ATUS), conducted by the Bureau of Labor Statistics, offers a different perspective by tracking how people spend their time.¹⁹ Data from 2023 shows that individuals aged 15 years and over spent an average of 0.31 hours per day participating in sports, exercise, and recreation.²⁰ This translates to approximately 18.6 minutes per day. When broken down by age group, the data reveals that those aged 15 to 24 years spent the most time, averaging 0.50 hours (30 minutes) per day, while older age groups generally spent less time.¹⁹ For example, adults aged 25 to 34 averaged 0.30 hours (18 minutes), and those aged 35 to 44 averaged 0.28 hours (16.8 minutes) per day.²⁰

Fitness surveys also provide data on exercise habits. One survey conducted by Myprotein found that the average American works out for 7.6 hours each week, which is just over an hour per day.²² This survey also distinguished between total time spent on health and fitness regimes (including meal preparation) and actual workout time, with the former averaging 11.7 hours per week.²² It's important to note that the definition of "working out" in such surveys might encompass a broader range of activities than strictly structured exercise.

Other research highlights a potential decline in physical activity levels over time. A Harvard study comparing 19th- and 21st-century Americans suggested a half-hour decline in daily physical activity, attributing it to technological advancements that have reduced the need for physical exertion in daily life.²³

The discrepancy in average daily exercise time reported across different sources likely stems from variations in how "exercise" or "physical activity" is defined and measured.²⁴ The NHIS data focuses on adherence to specific guidelines, while the ATUS measures time spent in leisure and sports activities, and fitness surveys often rely on self-reported workout durations. Self-reported data, as suggested by some studies, may also tend to overestimate actual physical activity levels compared to objective measures.³²

Demographic Variations in Exercise Habits:

Exercise habits in the US vary significantly across different demographic groups. Age is a

prominent factor influencing physical activity levels.¹⁶ The NHIS data from 2020 indicates that the percentage of adults meeting both aerobic and muscle-strengthening guidelines generally decreases with age, from 41.3% among those aged 18-34 to only 15.3% for those aged 65 and over for men, and from 28.7% to 10.8% for women in the same age groups.¹⁶ Similarly, the ATUS data shows that teenagers and young adults tend to spend more time participating in sports and exercise compared to older adults.¹⁹

Gender differences in exercise habits are also observed, although the findings can be somewhat varied depending on the study.²² Some surveys, like the one from Myprotein, suggest that women might spend slightly more time on their overall health and fitness regime per week (12 hours vs. 11.5 hours for men) and also slightly more time working out (8 hours vs. 7.5 hours).²² However, other research, such as a study published in *Preventive Medicine*, found that men spent more time on leisure-time physical activity (an average of 24 minutes per day) compared to women (14 minutes per day).³⁵ The NHIS data also reveals gender-based differences in meeting physical activity guidelines across different age cohorts.¹⁶ Globally, a survey mentioned in a World Economic Forum article indicated that men spend more time on physical exercise per week than women.³⁶ These variations suggest that the type and intensity of activity, as well as the specific population being studied, can influence the observed gender differences.

Race/ethnicity and socioeconomic status are also associated with differences in physical activity levels.³⁴ CDC data from 2017-2020 shows variations in the prevalence of self-reported physical inactivity across different states and among various racial and ethnic groups.³⁷ For instance, the prevalence of physical inactivity ranged from 17.7% in Colorado to 31.1% in Arkansas overall. Among racial/ethnic groups, the prevalence also varied, highlighting potential disparities in access to resources or cultural factors influencing activity levels.³⁷ A study analyzing free time and physical activity found differences based on race/ethnicity, education level, and income, with those with higher education and income generally reporting more leisure-time physical activity.³⁴

Marital status and education level can also play a role in exercise habits.³⁴ For example, the meta-analysis of physical activity levels in US adults³⁴ showed variations in physical activity levels based on marital status and education level, further underscoring the complex interplay of demographic factors in shaping exercise behaviors.

Comparison of Recommended Guidelines and Actual Exercise Levels:

A direct comparison between the recommended 30 minutes of moderate-intensity exercise per day and the average times reported in research reveals a notable gap for a significant portion of the US adult population.¹⁶ While some studies indicate an average around or slightly below this 30-minute mark (like the ATUS data for younger adults or the Myprotein survey's workout time), the NHIS data paints a clearer picture of widespread underachievement of the guidelines. The fact that less than a quarter of adults meet both aerobic and muscle-strengthening recommendations¹⁶ underscores this gap.

Several factors may contribute to this discrepancy. Time constraints are frequently cited as a major barrier to exercise.¹ Lack of access to safe and convenient places to be physically

active, as well as a lack of motivation or awareness of the benefits of exercise, can also play a significant role.¹ The increasing prevalence of sedentary behaviors, driven by technology and changes in work environments, further exacerbates this issue.²³ The fact that a substantial percentage of adults do not meet either the aerobic or muscle-strengthening guidelines¹⁶ suggests a broader challenge in integrating physical activity into daily life.

Methodological Considerations in Measuring Physical Activity:

The accuracy of reported average exercise times is significantly influenced by the methods used to assess physical activity.³² Various methods are employed, each with its own strengths and limitations. Self-report surveys and questionnaires are commonly used due to their ease of administration and low cost.³² However, these methods are susceptible to recall bias and social desirability bias, potentially leading to overestimation of physical activity.³²

Objective measures, such as accelerometers and pedometers, provide more direct assessments of movement.³² Accelerometers can capture the intensity, frequency, and duration of physical activity, while pedometers primarily measure steps taken.⁴¹ However, these devices also have limitations, such as potential wear-time bias if participants do not consistently wear them, and pedometers may not accurately capture all types of physical activity, like swimming or cycling.⁴¹ Activity diaries involve participants recording their activities over a period, but they can be burdensome and prone to reporting inaccuracies.⁴³ Indirect methods like doubly labeled water are considered the gold standard for measuring total energy expenditure over extended periods but are expensive and not practical for large-scale studies focused on activity patterns.¹²

Studies have shown discrepancies between physical activity levels reported through self-report methods and those measured objectively.³² This highlights the importance of considering the measurement method when interpreting data on exercise levels. Furthermore, the lack of a standardized definition of "exercise" or "physical activity" across different studies²⁴ can contribute to variations in reported averages. For instance, some studies might only consider structured exercise, while others include all forms of physical activity, including occupational or household activities.

Conclusion:

In conclusion, while the recommended daily exercise time for adults in the US is around 30 minutes of moderate-intensity activity, the average time spent engaging in sports, exercise, and recreation appears to be lower, with significant variations depending on the measurement method and the population studied. National surveys indicate that a substantial portion of the adult population does not meet the recommended physical activity guidelines. Exercise habits are also influenced by various demographic factors, including age, gender, race/ethnicity, and socioeconomic status. The gap between recommended and actual activity levels underscores the need for continued efforts to promote physical activity and address the barriers that prevent many Americans from leading more active lives.

Recommendations:

To increase physical activity levels across the US population, several strategies can be considered:

1. **Public Health Initiatives:** Implement broad public health campaigns to raise awareness about the importance of physical activity and the recommended guidelines. These initiatives should emphasize that even small amounts of activity are beneficial and can be incorporated into daily routines.⁵
2. **Addressing Barriers:** Develop targeted interventions to address common barriers to exercise, such as lack of time, access to facilities, and motivation. This could include promoting workplace wellness programs, creating more accessible and safe public spaces for physical activity, and offering resources and support for individuals to develop and maintain active lifestyles.
3. **Standardized Measurement:** Encourage the use of more standardized and objective measures in future research to obtain a more accurate understanding of physical activity levels in the US population. This will allow for better comparisons across studies and more effective evaluation of interventions.
4. **Targeted Interventions:** Develop tailored interventions for specific demographic groups that exhibit lower levels of physical activity, taking into account their unique challenges and facilitators. For example, programs designed for older adults might focus on balance and fall prevention in addition to aerobic and muscle-strengthening activities.⁴
5. **Further Research:** Conduct ongoing research to better understand the factors influencing physical activity behaviors and to evaluate the effectiveness of different interventions aimed at increasing activity levels. This includes exploring the impact of environmental and policy changes on population-wide physical activity.

By implementing these recommendations, public health efforts can strive to bridge the gap between recommended guidelines and actual exercise levels, ultimately leading to a healthier and more active US population.

Table 1: Recommended Physical Activity Guidelines for US Adults

Age Group	Type of Activity	Recommended Amount
Adults (18-64)	Moderate-intensity aerobic activity	At least 150 minutes per week (e.g., 30 minutes, 5 days a week)
Adults (18-64)	Vigorous-intensity aerobic activity	At least 75 minutes per week
Adults (18-64)	Equivalent combination of moderate and vigorous	Aim for a mix totaling at least 150 minutes of moderate-intensity equivalent
Adults (18-64)	Muscle-strengthening activities	At least 2 days per week, working all major muscle groups
Older Adults (65+)	Moderate-intensity aerobic activity	Same as adults, or as much as abilities allow
Older Adults (65+)	Muscle-strengthening activities	At least 2 days per week, working all major muscle

		groups
Older Adults (65+)	Balance exercises	If at risk of falls
Pregnant/Postpartum	Moderate-intensity aerobic activity	At least 150 minutes per week, spread throughout the week

Table 2: Average Daily Time Spent in Sports, Exercise, and Recreation by Age Group (2023)

Age Group	Average Hours per Day	Average Minutes per Day
Total, 15 years and over	0.31	18.6
15 to 24 years	0.50	30.0
25 to 34 years	0.30	18.0
35 to 44 years	0.28	16.8
45 to 54 years	0.23	13.8
55 to 64 years	0.26	15.6
65 years and over	0.30	18.0

Table 3: Percentage of Adults Meeting Physical Activity Guidelines (2020)

Category	Percentage of Adults
Met both aerobic and muscle-strengthening guidelines	24.2%
Met only aerobic guidelines	22.7%
Met only muscle-strengthening guidelines	6.8%
Did not meet the guidelines for either type of activity	46.3%

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